POWERPLAY — Player Primer

A first-timer's walkthrough. Read this once, then keep the reference cards (Quick / Round / Turn / Mechanics / Ladder & Turn) handy at the table.

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1. Welcome to the Boardroom

PowerPlay is a corporate-satire strategy card and token game for **3–5 players**. Each player runs a thinly-disguised shell of an industrial empire, trying to amass more **Power** than the rest of the table by the end of the fiscal year.

You'll buy **Assets** (Tier 1 → Tier 3), play **Actions** to attack the competition, **React** out of turn whenever an Action, Synergy fire, or Event triggers, and convert **Coins** → **Influence** → **Power** at every opportunity.

The game runs **4 rounds** — one round per fiscal quarter, a full fiscal year per game. Each player takes **8 turns** (2 per round).

> *"In a free market, your value is whatever you can convince someone else it is."*

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2. What's on the Table

The CEOs have catered the boardroom. When the table is set up, you should see:

- **7 card piles**:
  - 1 **Action** deck (a single pile — no tiers) — what you do TO other players.
  - 1 **Reaction** deck (a single pile — no tiers) — how you respond out of turn when an Action, Asset Synergy fire, or Event triggers.
  - 3 **Asset** piles (T1, T2, T3) — the companies you buy that generate income.
  - 1 **Event** deck — the market events that hit everyone, twice a round.
  - 1 **Character** deck — the personas you'll pick from at setup.
- **Per-player counters** (one set at each seat): **Power (P)**, **Influence (IP)**, **Coins (C)**, **Loans**.
- **Power Track** (one dial per seat) — tracks your current Power on a face reading **0–9, then 10 → 100**. Labels mark what each level unlocks: **1 = your Character Ability**, **2 = Tier 2**, **3 = Tier 3**, **4 = PowerPlay!** — one new thing per step. It's just a visible readout of your Power (the win condition *and* your access gate) — move the dial up or down as you gain or spend Power.
- **Two Deal Tokens per player** — each deal you make costs you one; both come back every Opening Bell.
- **Two Reroll Tokens per player** — spend one to reroll a single income die. Once both are gone, they're gone for the game.
- **Per-color IOU template** (one per seat color) — used to record debts owed to that color player.
- **Income dice** — a D4, D6, and D10 (you roll one per Asset tier you own at Call-it-a-Night).
- **One Leader Token** that travels around the table each round.

> ⚠ **Quick orientation**: Power is the win condition and your access gate. Influence buys the Influencing Decision (a third Asset fire) and converts into Power. Coins buy Assets and cards and pay debts. You'll convert between them constantly.

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3. Setup, Step by Step (The Shareholder Onboarding Packet)

1. **Pick a character.** The Character deck is the only deck dealt face-up at setup — each player picks one. Your character has printed **Starting Stats** (Coins and Influence) and a special **Character Ability**. Set your counters to those starting values. **Every character starts with 0 Power** — Power is earned entirely in play. Set your Power Track dial to 0 and take your 2 Deal Tokens and 2 Reroll Tokens.
2. **Deal Starting Hand.** Each player draws **3 Action cards** and **2 Reaction cards** from the Action and Reaction decks. All Action and Reaction cards are free to play, with no Power requirement — every player can use their starting hand immediately.
3. **Determine the Leader.** Pick the first player by one of the Manual's (gloriously arbitrary) tiebreakers — most recent foreign trip, priciest watch or car, or who used the toilet last — and give them the **Leader Token** for Round 1. *(Everyone starts at 0 Power, so it's not a Power contest.)*
4. **Hand refill target**: 3 Actions + 2 Reactions. Your hand is refilled to this at the start of each round (Opening Bell), not capped per turn — during the round you simply play your hand down. There's no end-of-turn discard.
5. **Done.** Your first Morning News phase begins now. The game runs 4 rounds — no length to choose.

> ⚠ **Tip**: Don't agonize over character choice — every character is built to the same equity standard, so there's no objectively-best pick. Pick the one whose ability fits how you like to play (information, trading, or capital).

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4. The Round in 7 Phases (One Fiscal Quarter)

The market opens, the market gossips, the market closes. A round batches all the upkeep up front so that when it's finally your turn, you just *play*. Every phase runs in **turn order from the Leader** unless noted, in this order:

Phase 1 — Morning News

- Draw 1 Event card (the **Morning News**) and **read it aloud**, then resolve it. Some Events fire once and end ("one-shot"); others stay active ("ongoing") **until the next round's Morning News replaces this one**. Every Event also carries an **Event Objective** — an easy-to-check goal that pays **1 Power** to *any* player who hits it (in the moment, once each). Climbing Power this way is the main route to bigger tiers.

Phase 2 — Opening Bell (Batch Upkeep)

This is a short one. In turn order:

- **Draw Hands**: discard any cards you don't want, then **refill to 3 Action + 2 Reaction** (this refill is free).
- **Refill Deal Tokens**: return your Deal Tokens to 2.

That's the whole phase — a free hand and Deal Token refill. Income is rolled at the *end* of the round, at Call-it-a-Night (so your last round's income is there to settle your debts). Card *buying* is not here either: it happens at **The Inbox**, the start of each of your turns (§ 5).

> ⚠ **Why refill up front?** Everyone has a fresh hand *before* the bidding and the turns begin — and the Market Operation draft (next) is fought with whatever Coins you banked last night.

Phase 3 — Market Operation (Pre-Market Sealed-Bid Draft)

Opt in if you want to shop. In turn order from the Leader, each participant pulls one Asset into a shared row (gated by Pull eligibility — T1: any participant; T2: 2 P **and** 4 Coins; T3: 3 P **and** 7 Coins). Everyone then **secretly commits a Coin bid** in a closed hand and reveals at once. The highest bid picks an Asset **of the tier they pulled** (or a higher tier they qualify for) and **pays their bid** (minimum ½ its printed cost — T1 ≥ 2 / T2 ≥ 4 / T3 ≥ 7), then the next-highest picks, and so on. You can only drop to a *lower* tier if nothing of your tier is left in the row — then you take the highest tier still available and still pay your full bid, even if that means paying a Tier 3 bid for a Tier 1. Down to 1 Coin? You bid it

all-in, resolve last, and grab a leftover. Ties go to turn order from the Leader. Leftovers go to the bottom of their decks. The Draft is the cheap, competitive way to buy — the Lunch Break's Private Equity is the pricier, on-demand way.

> ⚠ **Pull what you mean to buy.** Pulling a T3 to bait rivals is no longer free — if T3s are still on the row when your turn comes, you're buying a T3 (or walking away). Round 1 is fought with starting Coins only, since nobody has rolled income yet.

> ⚠ **Draft subtlety**: Bidding is blind and you pay exactly what you bid — overbid and you overpay, underbid and a rival snipes the Asset you wanted. Pulling a pricey card into the row can also bait a competitor into spending big.

> ⚠ **Tip**: don't bid away your whole wallet — keep a Coin or two in reserve for Inbox card purchases (Action 2 C / Reaction 1 C) on your upcoming turn. (Synergy activation itself costs no Coins — the reserve is for Inbox buying only.)

Phase 4 — Market Manipulation, Phase 1 (First Turns)

Every player takes their **first** turn, clockwise from the Leader. Each turn is short: **The Inbox** → **Action** → **Organize the Desk** (next section).

Phase 5 — Lunch Break (Mid-Round Economy)

When play returns to the Leader, the table breaks for the mid-round market. Two sub-phases, in this order, each in turn order from the Leader:

1. **Afternoon News** — draw + read aloud a *second* Event card. It stays active **until the next round's Afternoon News** — so it carries over into the next round's first half, and two Events (Morning + Afternoon) are live at once, each with its own Event Objective.
2. **Private Equity (Broker an Asset Deal)** — pay a fee (1 C for T1, 2 C for T2, 3 C for T3), draw the top 2 of one Asset deck you qualify for, buy one at printed cost (with its Signing Bonus), discard the other.

> ⚠ **Where are loans, trades, and sales?** Anywhere. Loans (½ an unmortgaged Asset's printed cost, max 2 active), Asset sales (to the bank at printed cost, or to a player as a deal; never a mortgaged Asset), and deals (Action / Reaction cards, Assets, Coins, IOUs — never Influence or Power) can be struck **at any time you're not in the middle of something** — on anyone's turn, between your two PowerPlay! Actions, here at the Lunch Break, even during Debt Settlement. The only no-go moments: while an Action, fire, or Reaction is resolving, and while Market Operation bids are sealed. **Each deal costs each party a Deal Token — you hold 2, refilled at the Opening Bell.** A creditor can sell an IOU to a third party as part of a deal — the buyer collects from the debtor at Call-it-a-Night.

Phase 6 — Market Manipulation, Phase 2 (Second Turns)

Every player takes their **second** turn.

Phase 7 — Call-it-a-Night

End-of-round bookkeeping — each player settles their **own** affairs, in turn order. In this order:

1. **Income Roll**: roll **one die per Asset tier you own** — **T1 = D4, T2 = D6, T3 = D10** — all at once. The **number on the die is the Coins you collect per Asset** of that tier, and **each T1 Asset adds +1**. Frozen Assets still earn income (a freeze only locks the Synergy); both active Events apply. Not happy with a die? Spend a **Reroll Token** to reroll it (two per game, never replenished). Pay **Operating Costs first** (T3: 1 C each; T1 and T2: none).
2. **Currency Conversion**: convert your own Tokens at the standard rates — **3 C = 1 IP**, **2 IP = 1 P**. Any amounts, forward only.

3. **Debt Settlement** (loans + IOUs — see § 8 for details; you can still borrow or deal in the moment to cover a payment).
4. **Thievery**: if the **lowest-Power player** isn't already the Leader, they take the Leader Token and assign it to ANY player — including themselves. Ties → the earliest player in turn order decides.

If this wasn't the final round, the next round starts at Morning News. If it was, run **Clean the Books** (all outstanding loans settle now) and then the **Board Meeting** (final scoring).

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5. The Turn in 3 Phases (Your Time on the Mic)

Your turn is lean. Hand and Deal Token refill already happened at the **Opening Bell**; income is collected at **Call-it-a-Night**; Asset buying happens at the **Market Operation** and the **Lunch Break**; and selling Assets, taking Loans, and making deals can happen at any time you are not inside a resolution. Your turn is: **The Inbox** → **Action** → **Organize the Desk**. Make it billable.

A. The Inbox

At the **start of your turn**, you may buy cards — up to one of each:

- **Action card**: pay **2 Coins**, draw the top 2 of the Action deck, keep 1, discard the other.
- **Reaction card**: pay **1 Coin**, draw the top 2 of the Reaction deck, keep 1, discard the other.

Buying is optional — 0, 1, or 2 cards per turn. Note the pricing: Actions cost *more* than Reactions, because an Action card fires up to 3 of your Assets while a Reaction fires 1. There's no safety net — if you're out of cards *and* out of Coins, you wait for the next Opening Bell's free refill.

B. Action

You may take **one Standard Action** — and there's exactly one thing on the menu:

- **Play an Action card** — free to play. Resolve the card's base effect, and **2 of your Assets matching the card's primary Industry fire their Synergy clauses for free** (the Base). You may pay **1 Influence** for the **Influencing Decision**: the card's secondary Industry is unlocked and **1 more Asset fires** (from either Industry) — **3 fires total**. There are no Coin activation costs. Fires resolve **one at a time, in the order you choose**; each targeted player gets a chance to React before their fire resolves.

Leaving your Standard Action unused is allowed — no reward, no penalty.

Free Actions don't consume your Standard Action:

- **Character Ability** — once per round (across both your turns), **free** — no Coin, Influence, or Power cost. You must **hold at least 1 Power** to use it (checked, not spent) — your first Event Objective unlocks it — and each ability names the **specific moment** it can be used — check your character card. Note that most abilities fire during round phases (Opening Bell, Market Operation, Lunch Break, Call-it-a-Night), not during your turn.
- **PowerPlay!** — hold at least 4 P and pay 2 P → you may **play up to 2 Action cards this turn**; **one of them gets the Influencing Decision for free** (the other can still buy it for 1 Influence); draw 1 Action + 1 Reaction. Once per turn. This is the standard way to take a *second* action. Mind the dip: spending from 4 P leaves you at 2 P, below the Tier 3 floor, until you climb back.

> ⚠ **Big subtle rule**: PowerPlay! works even after you've already played your first Action card — you can still unlock and play the second one. So PowerPlay! into a second Action card play is a common combo when you have the Power to spend.

C. Organize the Desk

- **Attach cleanup** — remove any expired Attached cards from your Assets and from yourself. No base-game Action card currently attaches, so this is a quick slot for Event-produced effects and anything an expansion adds.

> ⚠ **No discard step.** You don't trim your hand at end of turn — you just play your hand down through the round, and it refills at the next Opening Bell. Loan maintenance and repayment live at Call-it-a-Night, not here.

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6. What Can I Do on My Turn? (The Quarterly Strategy Memo)

A common new-player confusion: **what exactly counts as a "Standard Action"?** The Board pays for exactly one per turn — and there's only one thing on that menu:

Choice	Cost	Effect
Play Action card	Free (optional: 1 Influence for the Influencing Decision)	Resolve the card's effect; **2 primary-Industry Assets fire** for free (3 fires, with the secondary Industry unlocked, if you buy the Influencing Decision). *(The only Standard Action.)*

Private Equity happens at the **Lunch Break** (§ 4); selling Assets, taking Loans, and making deals happen at any time you are not in the middle of a resolution. And these are NOT Standard Actions — they don't use up your Action slot:

Free	When	Effect
Character Ability	At the moment printed on your character card (once per round)	Free — no cost. Requires you to hold **1 Power** (checked, not spent).
PowerPlay!	Any time on your turn (once per turn; needs 4 P held)	Pay 2 P → play up to 2 Action cards this turn (one gets the Influencing Decision free) + draw 1 A + 1 R.
Asset Synergy	Automatically, when you play a card whose Industry matches the Asset	The Asset's Synergy fires through the Activation Ladder — you pick the target.

> ⚠ **Where did selling/loans/buying go?** The free hand and Deal Token refill is at the **Opening Bell** (start of round), and the income roll is at **Call-it-a-Night** (end of round). Buying cards is at **The Inbox** (start of each of your turns — Action 2 C, Reaction 1 C). Private Equity is at the **Lunch Break** (mid-round). Selling Assets, taking Loans, and making deals: any time you are not mid-resolution.

Example turn: It's Market Manipulation Phase 1 and it's your turn. (You already refilled your 3A/2R hand and Deal Tokens at the Opening Bell, and you bought into an Asset at the Market Operation draft.) The Inbox — you pay 2 Coins to buy an Action card: draw the top 2 of the Action deck, keep 1, discard the other. Action phase — you play "Hostile Takeover" (free); its base effect resolves and 2 of your Assets matching its primary Industry fire their Synergy clauses, one at a time in the order you choose. You pay 1 Influence for the Influencing Decision, unlocking the card's secondary Industry — a 3rd Asset fires. The opponent Counters one of the fires with a Reaction. Holding 4 P, you PowerPlay! (pay 2 P): you may now play a second Action card this turn, one of your Actions gets its Influencing Decision free, and you draw 1 A + 1 R. You play "Smear Campaign" as that second Action. Organize the Desk — clear any expired attachments (an attached Freeze would come off here). Done. (You'll get your *second* turn this round in Phase 6, after the Lunch Break.)

> ⚠ **Newbie trap**: You may have only **1 Standard Action**, but you can also use **1 Character Ability** per round and **1 PowerPlay!** per turn. Plus you can play Reactions on other players' turns. The "I can only do one thing" feeling is wrong — read the Turn Reference Card carefully.

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7. Reactions and How to Defend Yourself (Crisis Comms)

Reactions are cards you play **out of turn** — responses. They live in your hand the same way Actions do, and any player can play one in response to any trigger — an Action card play, an individual Asset Synergy fire, or an Event — whether to defend yourself, defend another player, or capitalize on the moment for your own advantage. Think of them as the legal team on retainer: you wait until a trigger happens, then unleash them.

Four things to know:

1. **Any Reaction can Counter any Action** — or any *individual* Synergy fire. There are no tier restrictions (the Action and Reaction decks have no tiers). Each Asset fire is a separate event with its own response window, so a 3-fire Action gives up to 3 separate Counter opportunities.
2. **Reactions mitigate, they don't erase.** Playing a Reaction reduces or compensates for what's hitting you — it doesn't fully negate the Action or fire.
3. **No Reaction-to-Reaction.** A Reaction can never be played in response to another Reaction — the chain ends at the first Reaction, every time.
4. **Response only.** You can't play a Reaction proactively on your own turn — a Reaction always answers a trigger (an Action, a fire, or an Event).

> ⚠ **Reactor vocabulary**: The player who plays a Reaction is called the **Reactor**. Anyone can react to anything — defend YOURSELF, defend another player, or jump in purely because the card pays you (the affected player always gets first right to respond, then turn order; one Reaction per trigger). The card's printed effect is yours. When you play a Reaction, **1 of YOUR matching-Industry Assets fires** its Synergy clause automatically — it checks YOUR Assets, not the Defender's — and **you aim it**: if A attacks B and you react, your Asset can fire at B, at A, or for you.

Nothing in the game is immune: every Action effect, every Synergy fire, and every Event opens a response window.

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8. Money, Loans, and Going Broke (Capital Discipline)

Currency conversion

At Call-it-a-Night (only), or any time a card explicitly allows it:

- **3 Coins = 1 Influence**
- **2 Influence = 1 Power**

Going the other way isn't allowed. *(Converting your own resources is not trading — and Influence and Power themselves cannot be traded to other players.)*

Loans

Take a Loan **whenever you're not in the middle of a resolution** — any turn, the Lunch Break, Debt Settlement, Bankruptcy Resolution. It is never a turn action. The bank pays you up to **floor(Asset cost / 2)** Coins; you lien an Asset of your choice as collateral (it's now **Mortgaged**).

- **Max 2 active loans** per player.
- **Maintenance fee**: 1 C per active loan at Call-it-a-Night, **except** the round you acquired the loan (grace round).
- **Voluntary repay** (at Call-it-a-Night): pay **principal + 1 C** → the Asset is unmortgaged.
- **Default** (missed maintenance OR over-cap): the mortgaged Asset goes to the discard pile, the bank pays you its printed cost, you pay back the loan dues, and you **keep the surplus** (1 C / 3 C / 6 C for T1/T2/T3). No elimination from loan default.
- **Mortgaged Assets still earn income** — the loan just claims the collateral if you default.
- **Mortgaged Assets cannot be sold** — repay the loan first to unmortgage the Asset before selling it.

IOUs

If an Action card demands a resource you don't have (insufficient IP, Power, or Coin), you take a **Coin-denominated IOU** to the Attacker instead.

Shortfall	IOU value (per missing unit)
1 IP	4 C (3 + 1 interest)
1 P	7 C (6 + 1 interest)
1 C	(X + 1) C

- **Cap**: max 2 NEW IOUs per Defender per round. Subsequent debt triggers floor at 0 (you just can't pay anymore).
- **Settlement**: at Call-it-a-Night, in Debt Settlement after Currency Conversion. Voluntary repay first, then negotiation, then forced liquidation.
- **Negotiation is open-ended**: forgive part, trade an Asset for partial credit, swap for future favors (non-binding!). Both parties have to agree.
- **Tradable**: the IOU holder can sell the IOU to a third party as part of any deal — the buyer then collects from you.

Bankruptcy

Going to 0 Coins isn't bankrupt — you're just broke. **Bankrupt** means you owe Coins and can't pay even after liquidating every unencumbered Asset. Outcomes:

- **Loan default → NOT elimination**. The bank takes the Asset; you keep the surplus.
- **IOU default WITH a negotiated agreement → NOT elimination**. The Attacker forgives, partial-pays, or accepts an Asset trade.
- **IOU default with no unencumbered Assets AND no agreement → elimination**. Your owed IOUs and any held IOUs are wiped from play.

> ⚠ **Cushion strategy**: Keep at least 1 unencumbered (un-mortgaged) Asset in reserve. It's your safety net against forced IOU liquidation.

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9. How You Win (The Board Meeting)

At the end of the final Round, after the last Call-it-a-Night runs, the Board convenes to determine who walks out the **POWER PLAYER**. Two steps happen:

1. **Clean the Books**: every outstanding loan settles now. Pay principal + 1 C to clear, or default (Asset → discard, bank pays you printed cost, you keep the surplus). **No elimination from loan default at this step either.**
2. **Board Meeting** — final scoring:

```
Total Power = Power
            + floor(IP / 2)
            + floor(Coins / 6)
            + floor(Asset Value / 5)
```

Where "Asset Value" is the sum of printed costs of every Asset you still own (4 C / 8 C / 14 C for T1/T2/T3).

> ⚠ **Why the rates differ**: Coins score at `/6`, Asset Value at `/5`. Owning Assets is intentionally a slightly better score-per-token than hoarding liquid Coins. Convert Coins to Assets when you can.

Highest Total Power wins. Ties broken by best-of-three Rock / Paper / Scissors / Lizard / Spock. (Yes, really.)

Sample scoring: A player ends with **5 Power, 7 Influence, 15 Coins**, and two T2 Assets (printed cost 8 C each = 16 C Asset Value).

```
Total Power = 5 + floor(7/2) + floor(15/6) + floor(16/5)
            = 5 +    3       +    2        +    3
            = 13
```

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10. Where to Look Next (The Compliance Library)

The reference cards on the table — keep them visible; the Board appreciates due diligence:

- **Quick Reference** — one-page summary of every system. Keep this in front of you.
- **Round Reference Card** — one-page detailed walkthrough of the 7 round phases (Morning News → Opening Bell → Market Operation → Market Manipulation Phases 1 & 2, with the Lunch Break between → Call-it-a-Night).
- **Turn Reference Card** — one-page detailed walkthrough of The Inbox → Action → Organize the Desk.
- **Ladder & Turn Reference** — the Activation Ladder, PowerPlay!, Power Floors, and Reactions on one card.
- **Mechanics Reference Card** — every named mechanic (Power Floor, Countering, IOU, Loan, Deals, Attach, Reroll Tokens, etc.) defined precisely.

The full rules manual is comprehensive — but the cards above will get you through almost every situation that comes up at the table. Save the manual for rules debates and edge cases.

Good luck. Try not to get eliminated. And if you do, remember: it's only fictional money.